

BPHI 406: Topics in Metaphysics

1. Doctrine of Participation

Term "Participation"

The term "participate" expresses the essential dependence of the participant on the participated and, at the same time, the absolute metaphysical excess of the participated compared to the participant. "To participate" philosophically implies the relationship of the finite entity to the infinite being, from the creature to the Creator. For this reason, all the works of God are nothing but "participation." Finite beings participate in the being of God, not vice versa.

Origin of the doctrine

The doctrine of participation, which states in a nutshell that wherever there are many things, there must be one in such a way that the multiplicity of members possesses some common attributes of that one, was first introduced by Plato.

Participation in Plato

In his *Phaedo*, things are said to "participate" in something else. He argued that every pure Form (Idea) is a unity that can be "divided over many." Somehow these Forms are present in or present to the world of becoming, from which they are separate. In his *Parmenides*, he presents a dilemma in the dialogue between Parmenides who believed in the Oneness of being and Socrates who argues for the multiplicity of being. The dilemma is, if the whole Form of man were to be in each individual Socrates, Plato, Aristotle, then it could imply that the Form is separate from itself. If only a part of the Form of man for instance were to be in each individual, then the implication is that the form will be many and not just one.

Pitfall

Plato left vague and obscure the exact nature of this participation so that it is difficult to determine either the logical or ontological order of the participants with the participated. Secondly, according to Aquinas, Plato could not clearly express the structure of participation with regard to the limited reception by the participants of perfection that exists in its source in a state of infinity.

Aristotle's criticism

Aristotle's criticism of the Platonic idea of participation denied that there are any separate, self-subsisting Forms of natural things. For Aristotle, (1) a thing comes into being by the composition of matter and form, and (2) its destruction occurs with the destruction of that Form.

Thomas Aquinas

Participation of Rational creature

Aquinas argued that rational creatures share in the divine order; in God's being. It underlies these three things, namely: (1) the human being as a creature, (2) the ongoing dependence of the creature on the Creator, and (3) the humility involved in "being measured," in contrast to the hubris of some Protagorean conception of "man as the measure" of all things. Thomas's choice of the term "rational creature's participation" implies that unlike in Aristotelian metaphysics, where "being related to God" is true of all creation, the human way of "being related to God" is peculiar to "rational creature" with higher perfection.

Static structure of participation

Some Thomists divided participation into transcendental and predicamental: the first type concerns *esse* and its transcendental attributes; the second concerns univocal formalities of a genus with respect to species and species with respect to individuals.

Transcendental participation

A genus is differently realized and actualized in the various species according to different degrees of participated perfection. Every created being participates in the *Esse* of God. Transcendental participation is the real composition of the subject and *esse*.

Predicamental participation

By this, the individual human person participates in human nature. Thus, in a static or structural consideration of beings, predicamental participation is the real composition of matter and form in essence and substance and accident in general.

The causal or dynamic structure of participation

Parallel to this static order of being is the dynamic or causal order. This Causal participation is likewise twofold: transcendental and predicamental.

- a. Causal transcendental participation is the production of the common *esse* of all creatures by creation. *Esse* is the proper effect of divine causality.
- b. Causality as predicamental participation, on the other hand, is concerned with becoming in the order of genera and species. Here the pertinent principle is "form gives *esse*" (*forma dat esse*), which seems to invert the causal relationship discovered in the transcendental order. However, the principle has two meanings:

(1) substantial form bestows formal and constitutive *esse*, inasmuch as it confers a specific kind of being;

(2) substantial form as a formal act of the essence is the true subject of the *actus essendi*. This form is the predicamental mediator between God and the existing finite being.

Three ways of participation in Aquinas

1. One receives in a particular way what pertains universally to another. This is the weakest sense of it. E.g., the species Man is said to participate in the genus Animal; the individual Socrates is said to participate in the species [genus] Man.

2. A subject is said to participate in the accidents that it has, e.g., a man of a certain colour is said to participate in that colour. Or a matter is said to participate in the formal structure that it has, e.g., the matter of a statue participates in the shape of that statue.

3. An effect that is not equal to the power of its cause could be said to participate in its cause. This effect particularizes and determines the scope of the cause by acting as the determinate recipient of the power of the cause.

Participation as limitation

Essence/existence composites do not essentially have existence, so they merely participate in existence. In the above explanations, it means that, for Aquinas, to participate is to limit that which is participated in some respect, not just merely to take part.

What is then the nature of participation that takes place concerning essence and existence? For Aquinas, essences do not exist essentially; rather, they participate in their act of existence by limiting the act of existence to the nature of the essence whose act it is.

Participation as a Form of Causality

Causes of generation

The causes of generation are nature, art, and chance, and causality here is always univocal. For example, a given horse is the cause that equine (horse family) nature begins to exist in a newly generated horse.

Agent of an effect

An agent, in this sense, has a particular effect; it causes the form to be in this matter. This means that created things are good because of their own forms and that their existence is a participation in the divine existence.

Dependence on God

The proper sense of participation in Thomistic metaphysics is the dependence of all things on God.

God as the first and final cause

Aquinas agreed that God is the first cause and the end of all beings, but he preferred to explain this causality in terms of participation.

The Problem of Pantheism

The pantheism of the Neoplatonic tradition implied that by participation, the creature has a part of God himself. But created beings do not possess part of God because:

- (1) it is totally excluded by reason of God's transcendence and unicity,
- (2) of the perfect identity of God's essence and existence, and
- (3) of the fact that this perfect identity occurs only in God.

Participation occurs through creation, the work of God's efficient and exemplary causality.

2. *Actus Essendi* (Actual existence)

Aquinas rejected the Neoplatonic concordism¹ prevalent in medieval Augustinianism, he developed a precise notion of participation based upon a new concept of *esse* as the *actus essendi*. It is from the concept of *esse* as the ultimate act that St. Thomas developed his notion of participation and his entire metaphysics.

Aquinas argued that in any subsisting extramental thing, there exist certain metaphysical principles, namely: one is the "essence" which makes the subsisting thing be what it is, that is, its definition; the other is the *actus essendi*, which gives the subsisting thing and its essence actual "existence."

This observation that the individual subsisting thing displays instantiation of a particular essence made Aquinas argue that what gives/confers actual existence to a subsisting thing and its essence is unique, in the sense that the perfection of *actus essendi* cannot be said to be common in the way an essence is said to be common.

For instance, the subsisting things instantiating the essence of horseness are said to be similar because of their horseness. Therefore, the essence of horseness is what makes horses the same under a common category.

¹ Classical historians of philosophy used concordism for Neo-Platonic attempts to unify Greek philosophy, or the synthesis of faith and science.

But the subsisting things instantiating the perfection of *esse* are said to be different on account of their *actus essendi*. Therefore, the possession of *esse* is what makes a subsisting thing unique and distinct from all other subsisting things.

Hence in what actually exists as a subsisting extramental thing, there is (a) an essence that makes the subsisting thing what it is, (b) an *esse* which makes the subsisting thing a distinct individual, and (c) an *actus essendi* which makes the subsisting thing a real existing thing.

Aristotle did not have the notion of *actus essendi*. So, that is Aquinas' contribution to the philosophy of being, which means that all Aristotelian acts were, in reality, "potency" with respect to the *actus essendi*.

Thomas saw the metaphysical principle of *actus essendi* as the "act of all acts, the perfection of all perfections," and "a proper effect of God," at which the metaphysics of Aristotle did not arrive.

3. Essence (*essentia*) and Existence (*existentia*) or Act of being (*esse*)

Created beings

Act of being (*esse*) and existence in created beings seemed to overlap in the ancient period since the philosophers from Parmenides to Aristotle were more occupied with the notion of coming into being than with such distinction. Aristotle described *esse* (to be) as that which brings an individual thing into existence.

The distinction became clear in the Middle Ages with the influence of Islamic philosophers who recognized the contingency of the created universe as distinct from God, the Creator.

Christian philosophers like Aquinas made a distinction between *existentia* (exist or appear) or *esse* (the act of being), *actus essendi*, and *essentia* (essence). Essence is the whatness or the quiddity of being; that is, the proper definition of a being. *Esse* is what makes an individual being to be in reality, that is, the perfection of all perfection, the inner perfection of a being. *Actus essendi* is what gives the individual subsisting thing (*esse*) and its essence actual existence. From the explanation of Aquinas, it follows that existence is an aspect of *esse* or *actus essendi*. *Esse* or *actus essendi* cannot in some sense be reduced to existence because existence is just part of it whereas *esse* or *actus essendi* is the larger perfection to which existence belongs. In other words, existence is not totally distinct from the act of being or *actus essendi*, and at the same time not identical to them. According to Aquinas, essence and the act of being are distinct in finite beings. A thing, for St. Thomas, cannot be unless it possesses an act of being – *actus essendi*. Though material beings are composed of matter and form, they are also composed of essence and act of being or existence as their fundamental metaphysical structure.

Immaterial finite beings

In chapter four of his *De Ente et Essentia* [*On Being and Essence*], Thomas was concerned about whether the immaterial substance is composed of matter and form.

St. Bonaventure had argued that since creatures, even the immaterial ones, are in potency in a certain respect, then they must in some respect be material because according to Aristotle matter is the principle of potency in things.

Aquinas blamed Avicenna as the original author of this position, arguing that the idea of universal hylomorphism is absurd. Aquinas argued that immaterial substances could not be composed of matter. Hence, all finite beings, material and immaterial, are composed of essence and act of being as their fundamental metaphysical structure which makes them distinct from the Supreme Being, God, as *Actus Purus* whose essence and act of being or existence are one and the same.

Three stages of the real distinction between essence and existence

Aquinas propounded three stages of the real distinction between essence and existence.

First stage

Thomas stated that whatever does enter into the understanding of any essence is composed with that essence from without because we cannot understand an essence without understanding the parts of that essence. But we can understand the essence of a thing without knowing anything about its existence. For example, one can know the essence of a man without knowing his existence. So, essence and existence are distinct.

Second stage

Aquinas argued that it is only One Being whose essence is its existence. So, in all other beings, essence and existence will be distinct.

Third stage

For Aquinas, a thing whose essence is distinct from its existence cannot be the cause of its own existence otherwise, it would have to precede itself in existence. But since everything cannot be caused by another *ad infinitum* there must be a pure existence (*esse tantum*) that is the cause of all other existence.

Mediaeval priority criticized

Existentialism

Modern existentialists, such as Søren Aabye Kierkegaard, Jean-Paul Sartre, and Martin Heidegger, maintained the distinction between essence and existence but reversed the Mediaeval priority of essence over existence.

Kierkegaard favoured the subjective appropriation of a thing over the objective essence. Sartre argued that since God does not exist, there is no given; hence, existence precedes essence.

Actualism and possibilism

Actualism

Most analytic philosophers, such as Gottlob Frege, Bertrand Russell, and W. V. Quine, rejected the distinction between being and existence and insisted that being and existence are identical. This is the notion that what is, is only what exists, and this is called actualism.

Possibilism

The school of possibilism argues that being and existence are distinct and that things that exist are a relatively small portion of beings that could possibly exist.

Adjusted Possibilism

Quine criticized the idea of possibilism by arguing that non-actual objects have no real criterion of identity, hence: "No entity without identity." His criticism gave rise to adjusted possibilism, which argues then that being and existence are identical even though not everything that exists is actual.

4. Chance

Etymology

The word "Chance" is from the Latin verb *cadere* meaning "to fall," "to happen," or "to occur." Chance, therefore, is understood literally as something that "just" happens. Two major components of chance are its unpredictability and lack of sufficient causality.

Chance in the History of Philosophy

Ancient atomists

Ancient atomists such as Democritus argued that the universe is constituted by atoms and the void. In the beginning, there were atoms in space that purposelessly collided with each other to produce the things in the world.

Plato and Greek Mythology

Plato, in *Timaeus*, spoke about a divine chance (*theia tuchē*) who often came to save humans from their folly. He noted that many Greeks worshipped Agathe Tyche, the goddess of good fortune.

Aristotelianism

Aristotle also observed that for Democritus, the universe was ordered by chance – automaton, that is, out of itself (auto) without any purpose (*maton*).

Aristotle, in his *Physics*, argued that certain things that happen follow the same pattern, but others do not. Those that do not happen *often* and some *seldom*. Chance, for him, is seen among those that occur seldom.

Purposeful and non-purposeful seldom events

But since not everything that happens seldom is by chance, Aristotle made further divisions between events that happen for a purpose and those that do not. Chance belongs to those without purpose.

Per se or per accident

He also made a division based on cause since chance could emerge from a kind of accidental cause. Therefore, just as things are either *per se* or *per accident*, so also are causes. E.g., if a black builder constructs a house, the builder is *per se* the cause of the house while the black is, *per accident*, the cause of the house. Chance belongs to *per accident*.

Accidental associate

Among the *per accident* causes, some are by reason of something accidentally associated with the cause, as in the example above. In contrast, others are by reason of something accidentally associated with the effect—E.g., An argument that may arise over the house built.

Chance as Per accident cause

Chance, therefore, is a kind of *per accident* cause that results from something accidentally associated with an effect, as the builder just chances to be the cause of the argument over the house built.

Mediaeval Thinkers

St. Augustine denied the existence of chance or fortune in the face of the all-controlling providence of God.

But Aquinas admitted chance even within the providential scheme of things, arguing that things happen necessarily or contingently according to God's will.

Modern era

Spinoza described chance as a deficiency in our knowledge of the cause of things. Hume argues that chance does not exist and what we call chance is our ignorance of the causes of events or things.

Contemporary era

Laplace and even Bertrand Russell state that it is an expression of our ignorance of the phenomenon's cause.

Chance in Causal intersections

Aristotle regarded what we call coincidence as the intersections of independent deterministic causal chains.

Accidental unity in causal intersections

There is an accidental unity in what results from chance, and also, two or more per se causes could be found as causes of a single event.

According to Thomas Aquinas, a cause can intersect with another cause and the clash of these two causes, inasmuch as it is accidental, has no cause. Also, what results from this clash is not to be reduced to a further pre-existing cause. Aquinas gave an example of a man prompted to dig a grave by a celestial body but found a treasure inside the ground he was digging. The grave and the location of the treasure are united only accidentally. The power of the celestial body, not God, cannot directly give inclination to the entire result that the man must dig where the treasure is.

Intelligent agent as a source of causal intersection

For Aquinas, an intelligent agent can be the cause of an inclination to this entire result because an intelligent being can order many things toward a single end.

Chance and free action

Some philosophers argue that human freedom requires chance because if our actions were sufficiently caused, then no one would be held responsible. Hence, for them, chance is a necessary condition for being responsible for an action.

Some theologians suggest that quantum mechanics shows that fundamental laws of the universe are stochastic or statistical rather than deterministic. This, for them, would allow the human free act to occur and also allow God to act freely within the statistical probabilities of the physical system without "breaking" any laws of nature. But others argue that it is too restrictive to confine God's free act to scrambling around in the sub-atomic basement.

5. Determinism/Fatalism

Determinism, as a philosophical theory, argues that there are conditions for everything that happens in such a way that nothing else could have happened. Many versions or types of this theory have arisen in the history of philosophy, though some overlap considerably. Fatalism is an attitude of resignation in the face of future events which one believes is inevitable, and one is powerless to do any other thing than what one actually does. It is an attitude of resignation in the face of determinism. The five major theories of determinism are Ethical determinism, logical determinism, theological determinism, physical determinism, and psychological determinism.

i. Ethical determinism

This is the natural tendency to desire good. For instance, Socrates argued that every person chooses what one considers best for oneself and objects to what seems to be evil to oneself. Socrates inspired the doctrine that virtue is knowledge and vice is ignorance.

St. Thomas Aquinas believes that no one could reject one's highest good if one really knew it.

Objection

Aristotle rejected the theory of ethical determinism because, for him, it is in conflict with the fact of incontinence; that is, one could know that something is evil but, out of weakness, still desires it.

ii. Logical determinism

This is the theory that the human will is fettered and that we do not have the power to alter it. Diodorus Cronus and the School of the Stoics developed this. The Stoics argued that every statement is either true or false, leading to the dictum *tertium non datur*; that is, there is no third truth-value. Diodorus developed a principle of logical determinism which states that "it always follows from the fact that something had happened that it was going to happen and, hence, that it was true that it was going to happen before it did happen."

Condestinate facts

To resolve this problem of Cronus, Chrysippus invented the idea of "condestinate" facts, that is, facts whose truth is dependent on one another. E.g., it may be true that one is going to recover from the illness, and also, it may be true that this will happen only if one consults a physician.

Pre-truth or pre-false

In his *De Interpretatione*, Aristotle suggested that the assertion or denial of future events is sometimes neither true nor false until the event has occurred or failed to occur.

iii. Theological determinism

Theological determinism states that God's creative act has entirely determined everything that occurs in the world. This states that the perfectly good, omniscient, and omnipotent God created the best possible world; it is, of necessity, the best possible world since he cannot inflict or permit evil.

Being omniscient, God knows timelessly all there is to know about his creation. St. Augustine, for instance, argued that divine omniscience knows everything beforehand. But God's foreknowledge does not constitute any threat to human free will because the fact that he foresaw everything does not make those things occur.

In the same line, St. Thomas Aquinas argued that God's knowledge is not the cause of anything by itself, and hence does not vitiate free will.

iv. Physical determinism

Physical determinism, which was developed in the 17th & 18th centuries, argued that heavenly bodies were not only regular but also "obeyed" certain laws that could be expressed with mathematical exactness. So, the philosophical or speculative approach in the study of those bodies gave way to the observational, experimental approach in search of those laws. This led to the idea that all things in nature, including humans, behave according to the unchanging laws of nature.

Thomas Hobbes denied the existence of any immaterial soul or spirit in humans. Instead, he argued, like many contemporary philosophers such as J.J.C. Smart, that ideas, sensations, and all psychological processes are motions or modifications of matter in the brain. He defended human liberty by defining liberty as the absence of external restraint or impediment. An unobstructed moving body is free.

v. Psychological determinism

This is the theory that we always follow or act in accordance with our greatest motive or desire or our strongest reason. In the history of philosophy, there has been a distinction by many thinkers like Descartes between mind and body, unlike Hobbes, who regarded them as entirely material. Descartes is a defender of free will and an advocate of indeterminism. But in the contemporary era, philosophers no longer speak about mind and body as distinct substances. Rather they talk about psychological and physical predicates. This is why most contemporary theories of determinism regarding human behaviour are called psychological determinism.

Determinism and its implication for human responsibility

In his discussion on liberty, David Hume argued that all men are free and that all human actions are causally determined. Freedom, for Hume, is the ability to act according to determinations of one's will or motives. Human action is not unfree because they are caused but only if they are caused by something other than the determination of one's own will. This notion of liberty, for Hume, does not vitiate human responsibility for one's actions.

Some critics argue that such type of freedom in Hume is only freedom in a technical sense. They argue that genuine freedom is not the one in line with volitions or desires but one that is avoidable, or as C. D. Broad puts it, one that is "substitutable" in the sense that the agent could have done otherwise.

6. William James (1842-1910) – *Judgments of Regret* in his “The Dilemma of Determinism”

Introduction

He was an American Philosopher who was born in New York City. He was a contemporary of Charles S. Pierce and John Dewey, both Pragmatists.

Explaining the background of the judgment of regret

James set out by asking how we can explain judgments of regret.

Determinism

James described determinism as saying that the fixed parts of the universe already determine and decree what the rest shall be.

Indeterminism

He understood indeterminism as arguing that the parts are, to a certain extent, loose so that one part does not determine what the rest will be.

Possibilities

Possibilities relate to things that may but must not be. Indeterminists admit that possibilities are true, but determinists deny the existence of such possibilities.

Chance

Antipathy to the idea of chance is the stronghold of determinism. This is the belief that possibility is nothing but chance. For James, chance is something purely negative because it gives us no information about that to which it is predicated other than that it is disconnected from something else. Chance seems to mean that something is not guaranteed; it may be otherwise.

Choice

James argued that the only ambiguous thing we are tempted to believe is the future human volitions. For instance, when one wants to choose between two roads that lead to the same destinations, a determinist would believe that one of the two alternatives has been from eternity impossible.

Judgments of Regret

For James, the problem of a deterministic world is the judgments of regret. For instance, pessimism of Schopenhauer, which is deterministic, describes murder as a vicious symptom because it belongs to a vicious whole. So, if determinism accepts pessimism, it can then regret not just the murder alone but the whole frame of things in the universe of which the murder is one member. Furthermore, if determinism allows judgment of regret, then there is no escape from pessimism.

Abandoning Judgments of Regret

The only deterministic escape from pessimism is to abandon the judgements of regret. History shows that it is not impossible. This is because, for James, we often discover that a certain amount of evil is a condition by which a higher form

of good is brought about. Hence, our deterministic pessimism may become our deterministic optimism at the expense of extinguishing our judgements of regret.

Indeterminism as solution

The only consistent way, according to James, by which we can represent pluralism and a world whose parts affect one another through their conduct is indeterminism. Regret itself implies the existence of possibilities in the universe.

Critique

A compatibilist could argue that moral responsibility and determinism could co-exist.

7. FREEDOM

There are three main meanings of freedom, thus:

- a. One is the possibility of the agent acting as one would satisfy one's aspirations.
- b. Second is the power of self-determination without any necessitation in willing the action.
- c. The third is the fulfilment of the reasoning subject by one's internal domination of reason or superior motivation over feelings.

Socrates was captivated by the first idea and declared that virtue and wisdom are interwoven. Evil or sin is a result of ignorance. But Plato conceived freedom in the third sense. Aristotle rejected the Socratic idea of virtue on the ground that evil can be willed knowingly. But there is no agreement on whether Aristotle affirmed the existence of free will though he affirmed the existence of choice. The Stoics maintained a strict causal determinism (a revival of the old idea of fate) but argued that one has the power to be the master of one's action. To buttress this, they retained an indeterminism in the physical world, insisting that the atoms can swerve in humans, thereby giving room for free actions.

God's premotion

Aquinas argued for the non-determining character of motives. According to St. Thomas, God pre-moves each man in all his acts to the line of conduct that one subsequently adopts. He argues that God adapts this premotion to the nature of the being that is being pre-moved. God's infinite power makes him to infallibly pre-move human, who is by nature free, to choose a particular action freely, but the lower animals choose necessarily since they have no free will. With the premotive decree, God foresees the future free choices of humans. But the philosophers of the Jesuit school who adopted Francis Suárez's version of Molinism regarded Aquinas' solution as providing sufficiently for the infallibility of the divine foreknowledge and God's providential control of human history. On

the other hand, they argued that it failed to adequately account for the freedom of the human will. For them, the relation of divine action to human will should be conceived rather as a concurrent than of a premotive character.

Modern era

Rene Descartes, with his *cogito ergo sum*, affirmed human freedom. For Spinoza, something is free if it necessarily exists and solely determines its act. For Spinoza, only God or substance (nature), in whom freedom and necessity are identical, fits this definition. Leibniz rejected necessitarianism and tried to restore freedom of choice by arguing that free act is characterized by spontaneity, intellectuality, and contingency. Finally, Immanuel Kant posited two types of freedom: negative freedom, which is the power to begin a series of phenomena, and positive freedom, which is the auto-determination of practical reason in moral law.

Contemporary period

In the contemporary era, Fichte exalted creative freedom as that through which the ego set up for itself a world where morality is to be practiced. Hegel sees true freedom in humans having within themselves the reason for one's own actions. This idea of freedom excludes contingency since it is an internalized necessity. Jacques Maritain argued that freedom of choice presupposes freedom of spontaneity, which he links to the ontological notion of *existence* in Aquinas.

Negative Freedom / freedom from

This is usually described as the absence of obstacles or constraints to fulfilling one's actions or wishes. This was advocated by Thomas Hobbes (1588-1679). It is often considered as freedom of self-realization. In this sense, one who wishes to be in prison is considered to be free. This negative freedom does not necessarily require an alternative course of action. If there is only one course, and that is what the individual in question wishes, the person is said to be free.

Positive Freedom / freedom to

This notion of freedom requires not only that humans be able to act on their desires but also that they be able to choose from many desires they present to them. This view of freedom is grounded on the theory of self-perfection, which gives room for some desires being more worthy than others according to the standard of human life that is regarded as good. Isaiah Berlin associated liberty or freedom with self-mastery, which makes one be in control of one's destiny.

Dialectical Freedom

This is rooted majorly in the philosophy of Friedrich Hegel (1770-1831) and Karl Marx (1818-1883). Human freedom is understood here as an opposition to some obstacles. The obstacles in this regard are physical and social. When one

obstacle is surmounted, another arises so that human freedom keeps developing or evolving. Marx would speak of human history evolving from hunt-gathering to slavery, to communalism, then to feudalism, to capitalism, then to socialism, which will end in communism.

8. John Roger Searle (b. 1932): The Freedom of the Will

In his work *Minds, Brains, and Science*, Searle tried to answer one of the worrisome questions about how human beings fit into the rest of the universe. We conceive ourselves as free agents. Searle sees freedom and determinism as irreconcilable.

Two reasons

- a. On the one hand, nature consists of particles and their relations with one another, which account for everything; hence, there is no freedom of the will. This is irrespective of whether physics is deterministic such as Newtonian Physics, or indeterministic at the level of particle physics, as seen in contemporary quantum mechanics.
- b. On the other hand, even if there exists an element of indeterminacy in the behaviour of physical particles, that is, that they could only be statistically predictable, it is not enough proof for human freedom of the will.

Image of determinism

According to Searle, the strongest image of this form of determinism is presented by Pierre-Simon de Laplace (1749–1827). Laplace stated that if an ideal observer knew the positions of all the particles at a given instant and knew all the laws governing their movements, this observer could predict the entire history of the universe.

Argument for the freedom of the will

Our choices, decisions, reasonings, and cognitions seem to make a difference in our actual behaviour. Experience teaches us on some occasions that we could have done something else. Human freedom, for Searle, is a fact of experience.

Philosophical Conundrum

On the one hand, the argument from physics gives no room for freedom of the will. But, on the other hand, the argument from experience has proof for freedom of the will.

Standard solution

The standard solution to the conundrum, for Searle, is that free will and determinism are compatible. Everything in the universe is determined, but some human actions are nevertheless free. For one to say that human actions are free means that we are not constrained or forced to do them.

Inadequacy of compatibilism

The problem of free will is the issue of whether we could have done otherwise. So, the problem with compatibilism is that it refuses to answer the question: "Could we have done otherwise?"

Free Will Based on Human Experience

Experience, for Searle, is the proof of freedom of the will because we confront a bunch of choices. But he asked how reliable our experiences are. For him, this proof of freedom based on experience seems illusory. We normally act on the basis of our beliefs, hopes, fears, desires, etc., but these forms of cause and effect are not deterministic, so that we could act otherwise. But is this not compatibilism?

Pragmatic approach

Searle now asks, what difference would it make if we accept either determinism or free will? Acceptance of determinism would make the world continue in its pretty way of physics, but some of our beliefs would be denied. But if we accept freedom of the will, it would imply making radical changes even in the physical world.

Why physics denies freedom of the will

According to Searle, we explain the behaviour of glass or water in terms of the behaviour of microparticles, such as molecules, just as the relation of the mind to the brain. Physics denies freedom of the will because it believes that mental features are determined at the basic microlevels of physics.

Impossibility of abandoning the freedom of the will

It is because:

- a. It is tied to human consciousness; only conscious beings are said to have free will.
- b. Life is not entirely about passive perceptions but also active ones.

Implicit conclusions

- a. The evidence of active experience suggests that the worry about determinism is unwarranted and false.
- b. The evidence of conscious, intentional experience gives us the sense that we "could have" done otherwise.

- c. But this form of compatibilism does not give us the kind of resolution of the conflict between freedom and determinism that our urge for radical libertarianism demands.
- d. Evolution has given us a form of experience of voluntary action in which a sense of freedom is built.

Criticism

The problem with Searle's argument is in his conviction that consciousness, beliefs, desires, and so on are mental or physical features of the brain. This tends to give the causal power solely to the neurons in the brain, thereby making freedom of the will difficult to establish. But his grounding of human freedom on experience is welcoming, though not enough.